

HISTORY OF ODISHA

Comprehensive Notes: Ancient, Medieval, Modern History & Freedom Movement of Odisha

Target Exams: OPSC (OCS/ASO), OSSC, OSSSC, Odisha Police & Teaching Exams • Standard Syllabus Coverage

1. ANCIENT HISTORY OF ODISHA

1.1 Historical Names & Geographical Identity

In ancient times, the region of modern Odisha was known by several distinct historical names depending on territory and period:

- **Kalinga:** Stretched from the river Ganges to the Godavari. Mentioned in the Mahabharata, Puranas, and Megasthenes' *Indika*.
- **Utkala:** Comprised the northern and north-eastern coastal parts of Odisha (coastal belt around the Baitarani and Brahmani rivers).
- **Odra / Odra-desa:** Referring to the region inhabited by the Odra tribe, primarily the central coastal plains. The modern word *Odisha* is derived from *Odra*.
- **Toshali:** The administrative headquarters of Kalinga under the Maurya Empire (divided into Northern Toshali - capital at Dhauli, and Southern Toshali - capital at Jaugada).
- **Kangoda:** Located around the Chilika Lake region (gained prominence during the Sailodbhava dynasty).
- **South Kosala (Dakshina Kosala):** Covering western Odisha and parts of Chhattisgarh (capital at Sripura/Sonepur).

1.2 The Historic Kalinga War (261 BCE)

The Kalinga War is one of the most pivotal military conflicts in world history, leading to Emperor Ashoka's transition from *Chandashoka* (Ashoka the Fierce) to *Dharmashoka* (Ashoka the Pious).

- **Year & Battlefield:** Fought in **261 BCE** on the banks of the **Daya River** near Dhauli (present-day Bhubaneswar).
- **Primary Sources:** **Rock Edict XIII** of Ashoka details the catastrophic war casualties (100,000 killed, 150,000 captured/deported, and many times that number perished).
- **Special Edicts in Odisha:** The **Separate Rock Edicts I & II** are carved at *Dhauli* (Puri district) and *Jaugada* (Ganjam district), declaring Ashoka's famous ideal: "*All men are my children*" (*Sabbe Munise Paja Mama*).
- **Impact:** Kalinga became the 5th province of the Maurya Empire with Toshali as its capital. Buddhist monk **Upagupta** initiated Ashoka into Buddhism.

Exam Tip: Ashoka's Rock Edict XIII mentions the Kalinga War, but the Rock Edicts XIII and XIV were omitted from the Dhauli and Jaugada sites and replaced by the Two Separate Rock Edicts!

1.3 The Chedi Dynasty & Emperor Kharavela

After the decline of the Mauryan Empire, Kalinga regained its independence under the **Mahameghavahana (Chedi) Dynasty** in the 1st Century BCE.

- **Emperor Kharavela:** The greatest ruler of the Chedi dynasty and a staunch follower of Jainism.

- **Hathigumpha Inscription:** Carved in Prakrit language (Brahmi script) on the Udayagiri Hills near Bhubaneswar. It chronicles Kharavela's 13-year reign year-by-year.
- **Key Military Achievements:** Defeated the Satavahana king Satakarni I, invaded Magadha, recovered the sacred **Kalinga Jina image** (taken earlier by Mahapadma Nanda), and constructed cave shelters for Jain monks at Udayagiri & Khandagiri.
- **Canal Project:** Extended the *Tanasulia canal* (originally dug by a Nanda king 300 years prior) into Kalinga Nagari.

2. MEDIEVAL DYNASTIES OF ODISHA

2.1 Bhauma-Kara Dynasty (8th – 10th Century CE)

- **Capital:** Guhadevapataka (identified with modern Jajpur).
- **Uniqueness:** Famous for rule by several prominent queens, including **Tribhuvana Mahadevi I**, **Gauri Mahadevi**, and **Dharma Mahadevi**.
- **Religious Stance:** Shifted from Mahayana Buddhism (Sivakaradeva I) to Tantricism and Saivism.
- **Trade:** Flourishing maritime trade with South-East Asia (Java, Sumatra, Bali) through port city Tamralipti and Manikapatna.

2.2 Somavamsi Dynasty (10th – 12th Century CE)

- **Founder & Unification:** **Yayati I** unified North Kosala and Utkala, making Cuttack/Jajpur key power centers.
- **Golden Age of Temple Architecture:**
 - **Mukteswar Temple:** Built by Yayati I (known as the "Gem of Odishan Architecture").
 - **Lingaraj Temple:** Started by Yayati II and completed by Ananta Kesari / Lalatendu Kesari in the 11th century.

2.3 Eastern Ganga Dynasty (11th – 15th Century CE)

Ruler	Major Achievements & Contributions
Anantavarman Chodaganga Deva (1077–1147 CE)	Shifted capital to Cuttack (Sarangagarh/Katak). Initiated construction of the world-famous Shree Jagannath Temple at Puri . Extended empire from Ganges to Godavari.
Anangabhimha Deva III	Completed the Jagannath Temple at Puri. Declared Lord Jagannath as <i>Rastra Devata</i> (Supreme Sovereign) and ruled as His deputy (Rauta). Built Barabati Fort in Cuttack (1229 CE).
Narasimhadeva I (1238–1264 CE)	Nicknamed <i>Langula Narasimha</i> . Constructed the iconic Sun Temple at Konark (Black Pagoda). Successfully repulsed invasions by Muslim rulers of Bengal (Tughril Tughan Khan).

2.4 Gajapati Dynasty (1434 – 1541 CE)

- **Kapilendra Deva (1434–1466 CE):** Founder of Suryavamsi Gajapati rule. Adopted title *Gajapati Gaudesvara Nava Koti Karnata Kalabargesvara*. Extended empire from Ganges to Kaveri.
- **Purushottama Deva:** Famous for the legend of *Kanchi-Kaveri Expedition* and marriage to Princess Padmavati.
- **Prataparudra Deva:** Last major Gajapati ruler. Contemporary of Saint **Sri Chaitanya Mahaprabhu** (who spent his final 18 years in Puri, spreading Gaudiya Vaishnavism).

Fall of Odisha's Independence (1568 CE): Mukunda Deva (Bhoi dynasty) was the last independent Hindu emperor of Odisha. In 1568, Bengal Sultan Sulaiman Karrani's general **Kalapahar** invaded Odisha, defeated Mukunda Deva, looted temples, and ended Odisha's independence.

3. BRITISH ANNEXATION & FREEDOM MOVEMENT IN ODISHA

3.1 British Annexation (1803 CE)

Odisha came under British rule in **1803** during the Second Anglo-Maratha War when British forces under Colonel Harcourt occupied Cuttack and Puri, ending Maratha rule.

3.2 Paika Rebellion (1817) – First War of Independence in Odisha

- **Leader:** **Bakshi Jagabandhu Bidyadhara** (Commander-in-Chief of the forces of the King of Khurda).
- **Key Causes:** Resentment against British land revenue policies, currency modifications (introduction of rupee over cowrie), salt monopoly, and dispossession of Jagir lands from Paikas (traditional landed militia).
- **First Martyr:** **Jayee Rajguru** (executed earlier in 1806 at Baghitota, Midnapore for opposing British taxation).
- **Course & Significance:** Paikas attacked British establishments at Banapur and Khurda. Supported by Kandha tribes under *Kamala Maharana*. Although suppressed by 1818, it led to major tax reforms. Officially recognized as a major freedom uprising.

3.3 Na'Anka Durbhiksha (The Great Famine of 1866)

Occurred during the 9th regnal year of Gajapati Dibyasingha Deva. Severe drought combined with British administrative negligence caused the death of over 10 lakh people (a third of Odisha's population). It triggered a socio-cultural Renaissance in Odisha, highlighting the urgent need for local education and administration.

3.4 Utkal Sammilani & Formation of Odisha Province (1936)

- **Utkal Sabha (1882):** Established at Cuttack by Chaudhury Kasinath Das and Gauri Sankar Ray.
- **Utkal Sammilani (1903):** Founded by **Utkal Gourav Madhusudan Das** at Cuttack to demand the amalgamation of Odia-speaking tracts into a separate province.
- **Pivotal Figures:** Utkalmani Gopabandhu Das, Maharaja Krushna Chandra Gajapati (King of Paralakhemundi, who advocated at the Round Table Conferences), and Pandit Nilakantha Das.
- **Formation of Separate State:** On **April 1, 1936**, Odisha was officially created as a separate province on linguistic basis (comprising 6 districts: Cuttack, Puri, Balasore, Sambalpur, Ganjam, Koraput) with capital at Cuttack. Sir John Austen Hubback became the first Governor.

3.5 Key Phases of National Movement in Odisha

Movement	Key Events & Leaders in Odisha
Non-Cooperation Movement (1921)	Mahatma Gandhi visited Odisha for the first time in March 1921. Utkalmani Gopabandhu Das established <i>Satyabadi Bana Bidyalaya</i> at Sakhigopal (1909) and founded the newspaper <i>The Samaja</i> (1919).
Salt Satyagraha (1930)	Led by Gopabandhu Choudhury and Acharya Harihar at Inchudi (Balasore district) — second most prominent site in India after Dandi! Other sites: Srijang, Kujang (led by Rama Devi & Malati Choudhury).
Quit India Movement (1942)	• Eram Massacre (Bhadrak): 28 people shot dead by British police at Eram on Sept 28, 1942. Known as "Rakta Tirtha" (Blood Pilgrimage) of Odisha. • Laxman Nayak: Tribal leader from Koraput who mobilized tribal uprising; executed by British at Berhampur jail on March 29, 1943.
Praja Mandal Movement	Agitation against oppressive rulers in princely states (Garjat states). Baji Rout (12-year-old boat boy from Dhenkanal) was martyred in 1938. Led to integration of 25 princely states into Odisha in 1948–49 (spearheaded by Sardar Patel and Harekrushna Mahatab).

4. QUICK REVISION SHEET: MUST-REMEMBER FACTS

- **First Governor of Odisha (1936):** Sir John Austen Hubback
- **First Chief Minister (Prime Minister) of Odisha (1937):** Krushna Chandra Gajapati
- **First Post-Independence Chief Minister:** Dr. Harekrushna Mahatab
- **Capital Shift:** Shifted from Cuttack to Bhubaneswar in **1948** (Architect: Otto Koenigsberger).
- **Utkal Divas:** Celebrated on April 1st every year to mark statehood (1936).
- **Gopabandhu Das Titles:** Given title *Utkalmani* (Jewel of Utkal) by scientist Prafulla Chandra Ray.
- **Madhusudan Das Titles:** Known as *Utkal Gourav* (Pride of Utkal) and *Grand Old Man of Odisha*.